



to get stronger and stronger.

And in Melbourne, when India were looking down the barrel, he came through the fire with an outstanding century that has cemented his place in the team for a long time to come. Ever since the unavailability of Hardik Pandya for Test cricket, India has been looking for an all-rounder who can bowl medium pace and bat as well. Reddy's bowling is still a work in progress, but as a batter, he is definitely better than Pandya was around the same time.

India must also keep an eye on Venkatesh Iyer, who can be another fine all-rounder and is a left-hander to bat. His bowling too can do with some work, but he has played in England and can be a very good option to have there.

Finally, coming back to the penalty that was imposed on Virat Kohli. The match referee, Andy Pycroft, who was officiating in his 100th Test match, had earlier in the year also levied a penalty for a similar offence on (Ireland's) Josh

Belligerent knock: Nitish Reddy became only the second Indian batter to score a century at No. 8 or lower against Australia, emulating Wriddhiman Saha's feat of 117 in Ranchi in 2017. AFP

Little. The maximum allowed under the offence is what Kohli got, so for the Aussie media to insinuate that he got off lightly is again a whole load of codswallop.

While the players and administrators in Australia have understood that times have changed and the veto power that England and Australia had in history, the media has still not come to terms with the fact that they no longer can influence World cricket.

Hopefully, they will wake up and smell the coffee soon.

Meanwhile, a Happy, Healthy and Peaceful 2025 to all Sportstar readers. May you have a sparkling sporting year.



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